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States Seek Review of Wages, Funding Pattern for New Rural Job Scheme

States seek review of wages, funding pattern for new rural job scheme

Four States objected to the scheme's blackout period during peak agricultural season; Jharkhand and Punjab demanded wages in line with market conditions, shows Centre's response to RTI plea seeking records of consultations on VB-G RAM G

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

With the Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Aajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-G RAM G) for rural employment set to come into effect on July 1, at least five States have sought a revision of wage rates and four had flagged reservations over the provision of 60 non-working days during the peak agricultural season. Three States, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh – both ruled by the BJP – and Jharkhand have explicitly asked for a reconsideration of the proposed change in the funding pattern.

The Union Rural Development Ministry shared this information on a Right to Information (RTI) application filed by Chakradhar Buddha of the National Campaign for People's Right to Information (NCPRI). Mr. Buddha had asked for records relating to meetings and consultations organised by the Union Government with the States regarding VB-G RAM G and the transition from the preceding Mahatma



Cause for concern: At least five States sought a revision of wage rates and four flagged reservations over the provision of 60 non-working days during the peak agricultural season. ARUN KULKARNI

Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA) to the new scheme.

In its reply, the government shared responses of only 13 States. Of them, almost all States had pointed to delays in wage and related payments, seeking early clearance of dues.

As per the interim allocation made under VB-G RAM G, Bihar will have to pay ₹4,477 crore. As per an analysis done by NREGA Sangharsh Morcha, this

amount is inadequate to keep the government's promise of providing 125 days of work. The analysis estimates that Bihar would have to pay ₹15,939 crore to achieve this goal. Similarly, in the case of Madhya Pradesh, the burden on the State is ₹4,168 crore, which would suffice only to provide 43 days of work. For 125 days, the financial liability on the State will be ₹20,037 crore. Jharkhand, to meet the 40% share, will have to shell out ₹1,804

crore as per the current allocation, which only suffices for 41 days. It will have to pay ₹9,293 crore to meet the 125-day commitment. Unlike Bihar and Madhya Pradesh, the two BJP-ruled States, Jharkhand explicitly said during the post-legislative consultation that bearing the 40% share will be difficult for the State.

Even States such as Sikkim and Uttarakhand, which fall under the 90:10 Centre-State sharing pattern [applicable to the

northeastern and Himalayan States], had sought a review of the clause. Uttarakhand, citing its terrain-related challenges, argued that the Centre should continue bearing 100% of the wage bill.

Of the 13 States, five demanded a hike in the wages of workers. MGNREGA wages were far below the market rate. Bihar sought a hike in the wages from the present ₹255 to ₹413, while Jammu & Kashmir sought an increase in the wages from ₹272 to ₹311. Both Jharkhand and Punjab argued that the wages should be competitive and in line with market conditions.

Blackout period

At least four of the 13 States objected to the scheme's 60-day blackout period, proposed during the peak agricultural season. The government had hailed this break as an important step to make labour easily available, while activists had criticised it, saying it will reduce the workers' bargaining power. Among the States critical of this clause was Punjab, which is heavily dependent on agriculture.

States Seek Review of Wages, Funding Pattern for New Rural Job Scheme

Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act

- MGNREGA is one of the largest work guarantee programmes in the world launched in **2005 by the Ministry of Rural development.**
- Rights based policy framework that guarantees 100 days of employment each year to rural households to undertake unskilled manual work
- It is a demand driven initiative
- Emphasis is on decentralised planning through Panchayat Raj Institutions. The act mandates Gram sabhas to recommend the works that are to be undertaken and at least 50% of the works must be executed by them.
- At least one-third of beneficiaries have to be women.
- Wages must be paid according to the statutory minimum wages specified for agricultural labourers in the state under the Minimum Wages Act, 1948.
- The employment will be provided within a radius of 5 km. If it is >5 km, an extra wage will be paid.
- Social Audit must be done by the Gram Sabha.
- **100% of the unskilled labour cost and 75% of the material cost (including wages of skilled and semi-skilled workers) of the programme is borne by the Centre.**
- State provides the unemployment allowance and compensation

States Seek Review of Wages, Funding Pattern for New Rural Job Scheme

Viksit Bharat - Guarantee for Rozgar and Aajeevika Mission, 2025

Ministry : Agriculture and Family Welfare

Provisions

- The Viksit Bharat Guarantee for Rozgar and Aajeevika Mission Gramin is the new rural employment and livelihood scheme that replaced the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme (MGNREGS) and will come into force from 1st July 2026.
- The scheme provides 125 days of guaranteed wage employment in a financial year to every rural household whose adult members volunteer to undertake unskilled manual work.
- It also mandates timely wage payments within 15 days of completion of work.
- The funding structure is designed according to state capacity, with a 60:40 Centre-State ratio, 90:10 for Northeastern and Himalayan states, and full (100%) central funding for Union Territories without legislatures.
- State governments can notify a combined 60-day no-work period during peak sowing and harvesting seasons to prevent agricultural labour shortages while ensuring workers still receive 125 days of employment during the remaining part of the year.
- The Act mandates preparation of Viksit Gram Panchayat Plans using spatial technologies such as the Yuktdhara portal and integration with national planning platforms like PM Gati Shakti.

States Seek Review of Wages, Funding Pattern for New Rural Job Scheme

MGNREGA

- 100 days of wage employment per rural household
- Multiple and scattered categories of works with limited strategic focus
- Center bears unskilled wage costs, states bear unemployment allowance
- No explicit statutory "pause window"
- Demand based funding with unpredictable allocations
- Gram Panchayat planning is central

Viksit Bharat-G RAM G

- 125 days of wage employment per rural household
- 4 clearly defined priority areas focusing on water security, rural infrastructure, livelihoods and climate resilience (Temporary assets to durable assets)
- State cost-sharing for wages, 60:40 for most states, 90:10 for certain special-category regions
- States can notify up to 60 days in a FY when work will not be executed
- Normative funding ensuring predictable budgeting while protecting the employment guarantee. Extra cost will be borne by state government (supply driven)
- Integrates institutionalised convergence and infrastructure planning

States Seek Review of Wages, Funding Pattern for New Rural Job Scheme

Q. Among the following who are eligible to benefit from the “Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act”? (2011)

- (a)** Adult members of only the scheduled caste and scheduled tribe households
- (b)** Adult members of below poverty line (BPL) households
- (c)** Adult members of households of all backward communities
- (d)** Adult members of any household

Which Document Proves Indian Citizenship?

Which document proves Indian citizenship?

Why is the Indian passport not considered a conclusive proof of Indian citizenship? What purpose does Aadhaar serve? Does presence on the electoral rolls or possession of an Electoral Photo Identity Card determine citizenship? What happens in case of a dispute?

Rizmi Lia M.
Priscilla Jebaraj

The story so far:

The Indian passport is not a “document of citizenship,” a senior official of the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said in response to a query from *The Hindu* this week. So, if a passport is not proof of citizenship, what is?

Is it a new development that a passport cannot be used as a document to prove Indian citizenship?

A passport by itself is not conclusive proof of Indian citizenship, and this is not a new development or announcement. Last week, the senior MEA official was responding to a question from *The Hindu* on whether the Indian passport can be used to challenge exclusion from the voters’ list through the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls that is currently underway in 16 States. The official said: “The passport is a travel document, not a document of citizenship, and theoretically speaking, that distinguishes the passport from other documents. Even though while travelling abroad, the passport attests to your nationality, it is not a document of citizenship.”

This stance is based on existing law. The government’s Passport Manual says that “a passport provides evidence of the holder’s nationality, but this is placed in the same category as any other evidence of the citizenship status of an individual”. In other words, a passport is strong evidence that its holder is an Indian citizen. However, in law, it is not treated as conclusive proof of citizenship. If a person’s citizenship is disputed, courts may examine it alongside other relevant evidence.

According to *Maneka Gandhi v Union Of India* (1978), issuance of passport is based on conclusive proof that the holder is an Indian

India does not prescribe one universal citizenship document. An effort to create such a document through the National Register of Citizens became politically contentious

national, and is “entitled by virtue of their Indian nationality and passports to the protection of the Indian Republic and assistance of its Diplomatic Missions abroad.”

Under Section 6(2)(a) of the Passports Act, 1967, the authorities can refuse a passport if the applicant is not a citizen of India. But under Section 20 of the Act, the Union government may issue a passport or travel document to a person who is not a citizen of India if it thinks that it is necessary to do so in public interest.

The MEA’s response distinguishes between evidence of citizenship and conclusive proof of citizenship. While citizenship is determined under the Citizenship Act, 1955, and passports are issued under the Passports Act, 1967, the existence of a passport cannot by itself be called a conclusive or definitive proof of citizenship in a dispute.

Can the Aadhaar card be used to prove Indian citizenship?

When the Aadhaar was introduced one and a half decades ago, it was promoted as a one-stop digital identification document which could replace the many documents that Indians had to furnish to avail themselves of benefits from multiple government schemes. However, from the beginning, the Unique Identification Authority of India has emphasised that Aadhaar can only be treated as proof of identity and address, not of citizenship. In fact, non-Indian citizens who are legally resident in India are eligible to get an Aadhaar, and often require the identity card to avail themselves of many basic services, from banking to cooking gas.

In its judgment of May 27 this year, when the Supreme Court upheld the constitutional validity of the SIR, it held that an Aadhaar card does not constitute proof of citizenship and, therefore, cannot be relied upon for that purpose. However, it is among the documents which may be produced for the limited purpose of establishing the identity of a person, it said.

Does a voter ID prove Indian citizenship?

Only Indian citizens are eligible to vote in Indian elections, but one’s presence on the electoral rolls or possession of an Electoral Photo Identity Card does not determine citizenship or conclusively prove it.

In the case of *Lal Bahu Shastri v. Electoral Registration Officer* (1995), the Supreme Court unequivocally held that electors whose names appear on electoral roll are entitled to a presumption of citizenship, and that this presumption cannot be displaced except by following the procedure prescribed by law. However, in this year’s SIR judgment, the Court emphasised that the Election Commission’s role is confined to determining

eligibility for electoral rolls. It cannot adjudicate citizenship, and the citizenship of an individual under the Citizenship Act will not cease on account of their ineligibility to register in the electoral rolls, pursuant to the SIR.

In fact, the passport was one of the 11 ‘indicative’ documents listed by the Election Commission as proof of citizenship. Some voters purged from the draft SIR in Uttar Pradesh, for instance, used their passports to prove that they are citizens of India and should be included in the final electoral roll. However, there have been reported cases of people in West Bengal who hold Indian passports, but who were still deleted from the draft electoral lists during the SIR.

So what document proves citizenship?

While responding to a question in the Lok Sabha on August 12, 2025, the Home Ministry did not specify the “categories of valid documents” required for people to prove citizenship in India. “The citizenship of India is governed under the provisions of the Citizenship Act, 1955, and rules made thereunder,” the Minister of State for Home, Nityanand Rai, said in a written reply.

Under the Citizenship Act, citizenship can be acquired by birth, by descent, by registration, by naturalisation and by incorporation of territory.

Citizenship certificates are generally issued to people who acquired citizenship by registration or naturalisation, and can act as a conclusive proof document. The majority of Indians, however, are citizens by birth or descent, and do not have a citizenship certificate. Instead, they rely on different evidence that prove their date of birth, place of birth, or their parentage, depending on the context of the dispute.

Anyone born in India between January 26, 1950 and July 1, 1987 is a citizen by birth, irrespective of their parents’ nationality. Such people would have to produce documents proving their place and date of birth to establish their citizenship. Given that mandatory birth certificates were not issued in this period, many people use a combination of other documents, including educational certificates and Aadhaar.

For those born between July 1, 1987 and December 3, 2004, proof of their own place and date of birth is insufficient as they must also prove that at least one parent was an Indian citizen. For those born on or after December 3, 2004, one parent must be an Indian citizen while the other should not be an illegal migrant, complicating the documentary proof required.

India does not prescribe one universal citizenship document. An effort to create such a document through the National Register of Citizens became politically contentious amid fears of a nationwide verification exercise that could exclude many due to incomplete documents. As former Foreign Secretary Nirupama Rao said in a post last week, the lesson is that “India needs stronger and more comprehensive civil registration, universal birth registration and reliable archival records so that citizenship can never become hostage to missing or inconsistent paperwork.”



An Indian passport. GETTY IMAGES

Which Document Proves Indian Citizenship?

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) clarified that an Indian passport is primarily a "travel document" meant to facilitate international transit, not a conclusive "citizenship document"

Section 20 of the Passports Act 1967, the Union Government can issue passports to non-citizens in the public interest

No universal citizenship document: A key issue highlighted by the controversy is that India has no universal citizenship certificate.

Former Foreign Secretary Nirupama Rao noted India needs “stronger and more comprehensive civil registration, universal birth registration and reliable archival records” so citizenship doesn't become hostage to missing/inconsistent paperwork

Which Document Proves Indian Citizenship?

Type of Passport

Blue (Ordinary) : Any Indian Citizen by birth, descent, neutralisation or naturalisation.

White : Indian Govt. Officials, IAS Officers, Indian Police Service Department Officials

Maroon (Diplomatic) : Indian Foreign Services officials, officers from ministry of external affairs, dependents including parents, spouse, children, official hostess travelling with the official, officials with diplomatic status, officials on Indian government-related business

Orange : Those who have not studied beyond 10th standard.

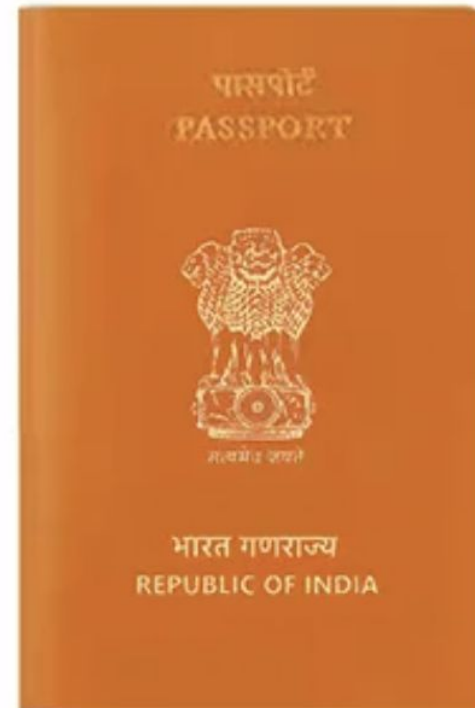
Which Document Proves Indian Citizenship?



Blue/Normal Passport
for Ordinary Citizens



White Passport
for IAS/IPS Officials



Orange Passport for
Indians who have not
studied beyond Class X



Maroon/ Diplomatic
Passport for Government
Officials

What are the Different Types of Passports in India?

EU Carbon Tax: Govt. to Shoulder 90% Compliance Bill of MSMEs

EU carbon tax: Govt to shoulder 90% compliance bill of MSMEs

The impact is likely to be felt the most by the iron and steel sector, where extent of decline in EU imports could be 24%

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, June 27

THE CENTRE is working on a scheme to absorb 90% of the compliance cost borne by micro, small, and medium enterprises (MSMEs) to help soften the disproportionate impact of the Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) compliance burden imposed by the European Union, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

India's efforts to secure a concession for its small industries in negotiations with developed countries have not worked, and the industry has been seeking assistance to meet the steep annual compliance costs due to the imposition of the EU's carbon tax since January 1, 2026.

The UK too has plans to impose its version of CBAM from 2027. CBAM is an EU policy designed to put a price on the carbon emitted during the production of carbon-intensive goods that are entering the EU.

Complying with the regulation is seen as a major global challenge, as declarants must track the embedded emissions of their goods, including direct emissions and, for certain sectors such as cement and fertilisers, indirect emissions. Industry sources said that the compliance cost for each

MSME unit to meet the requirement under carbon tax alone is Rs 15 lakh to 20 lakh and that they do not have the wherewithal to report the number of data points sought under the regulation by the EU.

India is the world's second-largest producer of both crude steel and primary aluminium.

Steeper challenge for MSMEs

An Indian exporter is required to submit CBAM certificates that correspond to the total embedded emissions. The regulation becomes a major challenge for MSMEs as the EU says that if exporters are unable to provide actual data, importers must use "default values" provided by the European Commission. The default values for CBAM goods have to be increased by a proportionately designed percentage "mark-up" in their value.

"These mark-ups are 10% in 2026, 20% in 2027, and 30% from 2028 onwards. Default values, including mark-up, have been determined to ensure that embedded emissions are not underestimated when applying default values," the regulation said.

"For MSMEs, the principal challenge under CBAM is not necessarily the carbon levy



The UK too has plans to impose its version of CBAM from 2027. REUTERS

itself, but the cost of compliance. Unlike large corporations, MSMEs often lack the technical expertise, systems and financial resources to measure, verify and report embedded emissions in accordance with CBAM requirements. They may have to incur significant upfront expenditure on carbon accounting, third-party verification, digital reporting systems and capacity building," Ayush A Mehrotra, Partner, Khaitan & Co said.

"These are largely fixed compliance costs, which means they do not reduce in proportion to the size of the business or export volumes.

"As a result, MSMEs bear a disproportionately higher compliance burden than larger

exporters, potentially eroding their price competitiveness in the EU market. If these costs are not addressed through targeted policy support, smaller exporters may find continued access to the EU market commercially unviable despite having competitive products," Mehrotra said.

CBAM impact on India

Imports from India would decline for all CBAM commodities, and the impact of the CBAM is likely to be felt the most by the iron and steel (I&S) sector, where the extent of the decline in imports by the EU could be about 24%, and the Indian Council for Research on International Economic Rela-

• TAXING CARBON

CARBON BORDER Adjustment Mechanism is an EU policy designed to put a price on the carbon emitted during the production of carbon-intensive goods that are entering the block

COMPLYING WITH the regulation is seen as a major global challenge, as declarants must track the embedded emissions of their goods, including direct emissions and, for certain sectors such as cement and fertilisers, indirect emissions.

COMPLIANCE COST for each MSME unit to meet the requirement under carbon tax is Rs 15 lakh-20 lakh.

tions (ICRIER) working paper released this month. The fertilisers and aluminium products, followed by metal products, are next in line. India's global export of I&S will decline by 5.7%; for China, the corresponding estimate is 1.2%.

This reduction is primarily due to a reduction in exports to the European Union.

The report said that CBAM shall adversely impact India's trade with the EU and will have a negligible effect on carbon emissions, adding that the impact level on carbon emissions is hard to determine and depends on the type of inputs used to produce the finished goods in the sector.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

EU Carbon Tax: Govt. to Shoulder 90% Compliance Bill of MSMEs

● The Government's Plan

- The Centre is working on a scheme to absorb 90% of the compliance cost borne by Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) under the EU's Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM)
- India's attempts to secure a concession for small industries in negotiations with developed countries haven't worked; industry has sought assistance since CBAM's compliance costs took effect January 1, 2026

● What is CBAM?

- An EU policy designed to put a price on carbon emitted during production of carbon-intensive goods entering the EU covering direct emissions and, for sectors like cement and fertilisers, indirect emissions too
- Declarants must track embedded emissions of their goods; the UK also plans to impose its own version of CBAM from 2027

● The MSME Compliance Challenge

- Estimated compliance cost for an MSME unit to meet the carbon tax requirement alone: ₹15-20 lakh

EU Carbon Tax: Govt. to Shoulder 90% Compliance Bill of MSMEs

CBAM is part of the “Fit for 55 in 2030 package”, which is the EU’s plan to reduce greenhouse gas emissions by at least 55% by 2030 compared to 1990 levels in line with the European Climate Law.

Govt. to Launch Affordable Digital Management System for Clinics

Govt. to launch affordable digital management system for clinics

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI

Aimed at helping small outpatient clinics that face challenges with manual processes and lack of affordable digital solutions, the Union Health Ministry is all set to launch the e-Sushrut@Clinic.

eSushrut@Clinic is a light Hospital Management Information System (HMIS), created by Centre for Development of Advanced Computing (C-DAC) to address these challenges by providing a simple, affordable, and user-friendly digital solution specifically tailored for small outpatient clinics.

“Large HMIS are often too complex and costly for these clinics and this results in small clinics struggling with inefficiencies in digitisation of the health system,” said a release issued by the Ministry.

It added that the need of having a government-backed and affordable

Ministry proposes to open light HMIS for govt. primary health centres, sub-centres and private clinics

HMIS has been coming from various microsite participants in spite of a large number of private HMIS players. Many States/Union Territories have also expressed interest to use a light HMIS for their public facilities.

The Ministry proposes to open the light HMIS for government primary health centres, sub-centres and private clinics, etc.

C-DAC implementing it
Currently, over 800 health facilities are onboarded on eSushrut@Clinic, generating over 680 health records. C-DAC is also implementing the eSushrut software, which is being installed at more than 15 AI-IMS and in various State government hospitals.

Listing the features, the Ministry said that e-Sushrut@Clinic provides a lightweight, cloud-based HMIS designed specifically for outpatient clinics which simplifies tasks like patient registration, billing, etc., thus making work easier and reducing mistakes. C-DAC will take care of maintenance and upgradation of the software.

“It is designed to be simple and intuitive, with no technical expertise needed from clinic staff. Also, this simple platform can be accessed from any device, without needing complex setups,” said the release.

The cost of eSushrut@clinic is estimated to be ₹499 per month for five users. A discount of ₹200 will be given making the effective rate to be ₹299 per month. The software will be offered at no cost for the initial three months. Each additional user beyond the included five-user limit will be charged at a rate of ₹50 per user.

Govt. to Launch Affordable Digital Management System for Clinics

● The Initiative

- The Union Health Ministry is set to launch e-Sushrut@Clinic, aimed at helping small outpatient clinics that face challenges with manual processes and a lack of affordable digital solutions
- It is a light Hospital Management Information System (HMIS), created by the Centre for Development of Advanced Computing (C-DAC)

● Why It's Needed

- Large HMIS platforms are often too complex and costly for small clinics, leaving them struggling with inefficiencies in digitising their systems
- The Ministry proposes opening this “light HMIS” to government primary health centres, sub-centres, and private clinics as well

● Current Implementation

- Over 800 health facilities are already on boarded on eSushrut@Clinic, generating over 680 health records
- C-DAC is also implementing the related eSushrut software, being installed at more than 15 AIIMS institutions and various State government hospitals

● Key Features

- A lightweight, cloud-based HMIS designed specifically for outpatient clinics, simplifying tasks like patient registration and billing — reducing mistakes and easing workload
- Designed to be simple and intuitive, needing no technical expertise from clinic staff; accessible from any device without complex setups; C-DAC handles maintenance and software upgrades

● Pricing

- Estimated cost: ₹499/month for 5 users, with a ₹200 discount bringing the effective rate to ₹299/month
- Free for the initial three months; each additional user beyond the 5-user limit costs ₹50/user

How Saving Elephants Helps Forests Breathe Easier

How saving elephants helps forests breathe easier

Rahul Karmakar
GUWAHATI

Protecting the endangered Asiatic elephant (*Elephas maximus indicus*) indirectly helps safeguard India's forests as powerful carbon stores, a new scientific study has said.

The research, however, warned that long-term carbon stabilisation cannot be ensured merely by declaring more areas as elephant reserves but by improving habitat quality, restoring wildlife corridors, and strengthening forest management. Carbon stabilisation, a vital mechanism for removing greenhouse gases and mitigating climate change, is the process of trapping atmospheric carbon and locking it into stable, solid forms (such as in soil or organic matter). This helps resist decay, erosion, or the release of carbon back into the atmosphere.

The study, published in the latest issue of the *Journal of Threatened Taxa*, assessed the relationship between elephant conservation efforts, the expansion of elephant reserves, and wildlife-associated carbon stock enhancement in India from 1992 to 2025. Noida-based Amity University's Tarun Kathula and Tanu Jindal are its authors.

The researchers found that India's elephant reserve network expanded from 18,297 sq. km. (across three elephant reserves) to 80,777 sq. km. (33 elephant reserves), while the elephant population increased by about 6.7% from 25,604 estimated during 1992-93. Despite the marginal increase in the number of pachyderms, the estimated carbon stored within the elephant reserves increased by 38%.

The increase should not be interpreted as the ele-



Elephants remain ecologically vital, despite their limited contribution to faunal biomass, the researchers said. THULASI KAKKAT

phants directly creating more forest biomass, the researchers said, as it "primarily reflects enhanced protection and reduced degradation of pre-existing forest carbon stocks."

The study estimated that about 95% of the increase in carbon storage resulted from the expansion of protected forest areas. However, elephant reserves are not uniformly conserved in the same

manner as legally designated national parks or tiger reserves.

Ecosystem engineers

Elephants, often described as ecosystem engineers, remain ecologically vital, despite their limited contribution to faunal biomass, the researchers said. The gentle giants, they pointed out, disperse seeds, enrich soils with dung, create space for di-

verse vegetation, and help maintain healthy forests capable of storing carbon over the long term.

The researchers also found a weak relationship between the number of elephant reserves and the elephant population growth, suggesting that administrative declarations alone cannot secure the species' future if habitats remain fragmented or poorly managed.

Declining numbers

The study further underlined a worrying trend – the decline in elephant numbers under a new census methodology called Synchronised All-India Elephant Estimate (SAIEE) 2021-25, while the number of elephant reserves has stabilised. The SAIEE count of 22,446 was 4,065 elephants fewer than the 2017 estimate, but the enumerators asserted that the two different counting

methods should not be compared.

Comparable patterns were observed in the African savannah ecosystems, where mega-herbivore management improved vegetation carbon stocks by 20-30%. "Such consistency across regions supports the ecological principle that mega-fauna protection complements forest-carbon goals," their study said. "Policy integration of these results can strengthen India's commitments to achieve 2.5-3 billion tCO₂ (total carbon dioxide) equivalent additional carbon sink by 2030. Incorporating wildlife-inclusive accounting within REDD+ frameworks could generate measurable ecosystem-service credits while ensuring co-benefits for biodiversity," the study said. REDD expands to 'Reducing Emissions from Deforestation and Forest Degradation'.

How Saving Elephants Helps Forests Breathe Easier

Three species: There are three different species of elephant: the African Savannah elephant (Endangered) , the African Forest elephant (Critically Endangered) and the Asian elephant

African elephants have **larger ears shaped like Africa**, Asian elephants ears **resemble the Indian subcontinent**.

African elephants have **two trunk “fingers”**, Asians have one.

Only some male Asian elephants have tusks, while both male and female African elephants grow tusks.

African forest elephants inhabit the dense rainforest of West and Central Africa, while African savanna elephants mostly inhabit the wooded savannas and grasslands of sub-Saharan Africa. They also differ physically. African savanna elephants are larger, and their tusks curve outward. The tusks of the smaller African forest elephant are straighter, pointing downward, and they have more rounded ears.

Elephant Lifespan and Reproduction: Elephants can live up to 65 years. Females reach puberty at 11, have a 22-month pregnancy, and stay fertile into their late 40s

Social Structure: A matriarch, usually the oldest and most respected female, leads the family.

They are intelligent species

How Saving Elephants Helps Forests Breathe Easier

Elephants in India: **India hosts over 60% of the world's wild Asian elephants (*Elephas maximus*), specifically the Indian elephant subspecies (*Elephas maximus indicus*).**

As the country's **National Heritage Animal**, they play a crucial role as ecosystem engineers, aiding in seed dispersal, nutrient cycling, and climate regulation.

As **keystone (ecosystem shapers), umbrella (protecting coexisting species), and flagship species (symbols of conservation)**, Elephants sustain tropical forests and perennial rivers.

Project Elephant: It is a centrally sponsored scheme, launched in 1992 under MoEFCC, Project Elephant supports 22 states/UTs in conserving elephants, their habitats, and migration corridors.

Project RE-HAB (Reducing Elephant-Human Attacks using Bees): It is an initiative by the **Khadi and Village Industries Commission (KVIC)** to mitigate human-elephant conflict using "bee-fences".

It involves strategically placing bee boxes along elephant paths to deter them from entering human habitations, thus reducing both human and elephant fatalities.

Elephant Reserves overlap with Tiger Reserves, Wildlife Sanctuaries and Reserved Forests which are protected under **Wild Life (Protection) Act, 1972, Indian Forest Act, 1927 and other local State Acts**.

The **CITES-led Monitoring the Illegal Killing of Elephants (MIKE) programme** monitors illegal elephant killings to guide conservation action

How Saving Elephants Helps Forests Breathe Easier

The elephant census is conducted once in 5 years under the aegis of Project elephant.

The **direct elephant counting method** is based on the sightings of elephants.

In the indirect method, surveyors follow a **dung decay formula** for arriving at population estimation which is being used by Tamil Nadu and Karnataka at present.

A variation of about 8% to 9% has been noticed between the two methods

Karnataka has the highest number of elephants (6,049), followed by Assam (5,719) and Kerala (5706).

Haathi Mere Saathi is a campaign launched by the Ministry of environment and forest (MoEF) in partnership with the wildlife trust of India (WTI).

How Saving Elephants Helps Forests Breathe Easier

● Elephants as Ecosystem Engineers

- Despite their limited contribution to overall faunal biomass, elephants remain ecologically vital, they disperse seeds, enrich soils with dung, create space for diverse vegetation, and help maintain healthy, carbon-storing forests over the long term
- A weak relationship was found between the number of elephant reserves and elephant population growth, suggesting administrative declarations alone cannot secure the species' future if habitats remain fragmented or poorly managed
- Elephant reserves are not uniformly conserved in the same legal manner as national parks or tiger reserves

● Declining Numbers — A Worrying Trend

- Under the new census methodology, Synchronised All-India Elephant Estimate (SAIEE) 2021-25, the elephant count stood at 22,446 4,065 fewer than the 2017 estimate even as the number of elephant reserves has stabilised
- Enumerators cautioned that the two different counting methods should not be directly compared

How Saving Elephants Helps Forests Breathe Easier

With reference to Indian elephants, consider the following statements:

1. The leader of an elephant group is female.
2. The maximum gestation period can be 22 months.
3. An elephant can normally go on calving till the age of 40 years only.
4. Among the States in India, the highest elephant population is in Kerala.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

This question was previously asked in

UPSC Civil Services Exam
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1. 1 and 2 only

2. 2 and 4 only

3. 3 only

4. 1, 3 and 4 only

Thank You